

## xbox pirates

Microsoft may go back on an earlier pledge to not use its Xbox Live online gaming service to crack down on mod chips—chips that modify the Xbox console to run copied game discs and unlicensed software. The new agreement states, “Microsoft may...retrieve information from the Xbox used to log on to Xbox Live as necessary to operate and protect the security of Xbox Live, and to enforce this Agreement.” Xbox hackers seemed unconcerned, saying mod chips offer a number of safeguards, including on/off switches and firmware that can be easily modified to bypass any new security measures. “The newer mod chips can already defeat any attempts by Microsoft to detect them, as they are firmware-upgradeable via a PC parallel port,” writes one mod chip enthusiast, Tony Dalton-Richards. “I don’t think this will affect modding very much,” adds Dan ‘SiliconIce’ Johnson, founder of the Xbox-Hacker Web site ([www.xbox-hacker.com](http://www.xbox-hacker.com)). “Mod chips can simply be switched off when the user wants to play on Xbox Live.”



## snapshot

Number of cell phone users in India to climb to **10 million** by the end of 2002 and **120 million** by 2008

Source: Reuters

## Turok or not Turok

Acclaim Entertainment is on what sounds like the most bizarre branding exercise for their next first-person shooter, *Turok: Evolution*, released on September 1 this



year. If you legally change your name to Turok, you get a shiny new console, a truckload of games, \$785 (approx Rs 39,250) plus the cost of

getting your name changed to and back from Turok!

Acclaim will also award the parents of the first child born on September 1 a \$10,000 (approx Rs 5 lakh) US savings

bond if the child is named Turok for one year, on the condition that it is born in a US hospital.

Acclaim has a similar promotion in the UK, where it is asking five British adults to legal-

ly change their name to Turok for one year, in return for around \$800 (approx Rs 40,000) and the complete Turok game collection.

## A new PC rating method

AMD challenges the most common way of rating computer performance, what it calls the ‘megahertz myth’. It has been urging consumers to question the notion that a PC with a faster chip will always outperform one with a slower processor. They argue that a less expensive machine with one of its own 1.8 GHz Athlon XP 2200+ processors can perform

as well or better than a PC using Intel’s 2.26 GHz Pentium 4 chip. AMD says that standard benchmarks tell only part of the story and that trying to juggle all of them only muddles buyers, especially first-timers. “Lightbulbs have better information about them at the point of sale than PCs,” says Patrick Moorhead, vice president of consumer advocacy for AMD.

## tomorrow's technology

### Dual-core chips from Intel

Enhancements in chip fabrication techniques have resulted in smaller transistors on processors and this will result in some interesting architectures in tomorrow’s processors. Today’s processors contain a single core with associated processing subsystems such as cache and data controllers. However, with the ability to pack greater number of circuits on chips, fabricators are trying to integrate two

separate cores into a single processor package. The low manufacturing cost, as compared to single-core processors of the same power, will ensure that dual core technology will eventually bring multiprocessing power to the desktop. Since the fabrication will be on the same chip, the speeds will be significantly higher than of current processors.

This is already becoming a reality—processors like HP’s

## quoteworthy

“PCs will communicate even more than they do today and cell phones will compute even more than they do today”

An Intel spokesman, when unveiling details about its first processor for laptops, named Banias.

“They (Microsoft) believe they are so big that they can take away what consumers want. They believe their size and momentum can drive an entire industry in a proprietary direction with technologies built by Microsoft. That direction is very much opposite to where most of the industry is going.”

Frank Casanova, Apple’s director of QuickTime product marketing, referring to Windows Media 9 and

new RISC-based PA-8800 processor (code-named Mako) integrates two complete PA-8700 cores, their integrated L1 caches and L2 cache controller on a single chip, along with an off chipset of L2 cache SRAMs. It has also been publicly disclosed by AMD that its new Sledgehammer processor will have two cores. Intel is, however, indicating that it would be ready for dual-core Itanium processors only by about 2005.